

guy. Same fifteen points. I sold some years later at a huge profit, and my father held it for decades, selling at a much larger profit, by which time it had become the second-largest

U.S. steel manufacturer.

I think my father, who was fifty-one when this book came out and a bit of an eclectic genius and already very successful, failed to see how the understanding of the craft, turning into an art, which had come to him slowly and intuitively over the years, would take time for a neo-phyte to learn. He regularly thought of things in his life differently than how he initially explained them. It was a quirky part of how his brain worked. As I write today, I am fifty-two, almost the same age as he was then; and I know, because I had to learn the process rather than invent it, that it takes time to learn.

I'm more linear than my father was and in many ways more intro-spective, and I urge you to read this book multiple times spanning your investment life. Take scuttlebutt, again. The scuttlebutt chapter is only three pages long. But they are among the book's most important pages. It is clear to me, in retrospect, that my father simply skipped the craft part of what otherwise might have been in the book. He just assumed it.

Over the years, I applied this process to lots of stocks on an individual basis, gaining great insights. The key? Focus on customers, competitors, and suppliers. I described the craft in my first book, *Super Stocks* (Dow Jones-Irwin, 1984), including how to do it with several real-world examples. My book was a good book, 1984–1985's best-selling stock market book. And I'm proud I wrote it. But it was not nearly as good as this book. *Common Stocks and Uncommon Profits* had much less that would become obsolete over time than my first book had; and while both books introduced new concepts, my father's new concepts were more radical for their day and more uniformly applied and more time-less—which is what makes it such a great book. My book was mostly about craft, not art. With craft, whenever you ask, you get answers. The art is to get more questions—and the right questions—flowing from the answers you receive to prior questions. I've seen people who rigidly run down a standard question list, regardless of the responses they get. That isn't art: You ask; he or she answers. What question best flows from the answer? And so on. When you can do that well on a